RESEARCH QUESTION · FLORENCE, 1494

The Price of *Democracy*

Should voting be compulsory to ensure that democracy represents the broader public rather than disproportionately reflecting highly motivated minorities?

The Medici family's influence over Florence raises a question that remains relevant: *who actually exercises political power?*

From narrow government to broader participation · governo stretto / governo largo



THE MEDICI FAMILY IN RENAISSANCE ART

Sandro Botticelli, *Adoration of the Magi*, c. 1470–1475 · Uffizi Galleries. Several figures are traditionally identified as Medici family members.

FIRST SOURCE

John Stuart Mill, *Considerations on Representative Government*

MAIN POINT

Voting is a civic duty.

Mill argues that casting a ballot should not be treated merely as an act of personal preference. Because political decisions affect the whole community, voting carries a moral responsibility to consider the public good.

> “It is strictly a matter of duty.”
>
> MILL · CHAPTER 10

WHY IT MATTERS

How this source shaped my essay

This source gave my essay its philosophical foundation. It helped me argue that compulsory voting can be defended not just as a policy tool, but as a way of reinforcing democratic responsibility.

Key idea: rights in a democracy are tied to obligations.

ADDITIONAL SOURCE · ECONOMIC THEORY

The *Paradox* of Not Voting

TIMOTHY J. FEDDERSEN · 2004

Why vote if one vote rarely changes the outcome?

Rational-choice theory compares the personal costs of voting with the very small probability of casting a decisive ballot.

> Individually rational abstention can become a collective problem.

Conceptual summary, not a direct quotation.

WHAT IT ADDS

The conflict between incentives and responsibility

Mill describes why citizens *ought* to participate; Feddersen helps explain why some choose not to. Together, they reveal a tension between private incentives and democratic needs.

Source: Feddersen, “Rational Choice Theory and the Paradox of Not Voting,” *Journal of Economic Perspectives*.

COUNTERARGUMENT SOURCE

John Stuart Mill, *On Liberty*

MAIN POINT

Individual freedom matters.

This source complicates my argument. Mill insists that people should retain authority over their own minds and actions, which raises the objection that voting should remain voluntary.

> “Over himself, over his own body and mind, the individual is sovereign.”
>
> MILL · CHAPTER 1

WHY IT MATTERS

How it challenged my position

This source forced me to make a real concession. I had to acknowledge that compulsory voting may infringe on autonomy, especially for people who reject every candidate or feel politically uninformed.

My response became more limited: participation could be required while still allowing blank ballots, privacy, and exemptions.

My research made my argument *more nuanced*.

INITIAL HYPOTHESIS — REFINED UNDERSTANDING

WHAT I FIRST ASSUMED

More voters = better democracy.

I originally believed that increasing turnout would naturally reduce the power of outlier groups and improve democratic outcomes.

WHAT I LEARNED

Participation changes representation.

- Feddersen showed me that abstaining can be rational from an individual perspective.
- Oprea showed me that higher turnout can move politics toward the median voter under certain conditions.
- Fowler found that compulsory voting increased Australian turnout by about 24 percentage points and changed electoral outcomes.
- Mill's *On Liberty* showed me that civic duty must still be balanced with freedom.

Australia: about +24 percentage points in turnout and +7–10 percentage points in Labor vote and seat shares (Fowler, 2013). These historical findings show real electoral effects, not a universal guarantee of moderation or better decisions.

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